

# **RECLAIMING ME**

A Recovery Workbook for  
Narcissistic Abuse Survivors

You are not crazy.  
It was real. It was abuse.  
And you can heal.

**Daniel Tesfamariam**

# **RECLAIMING ME**

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# UNDERSTANDING NARCISSISTIC ABUSE

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## The Cycle of Narcissistic Abuse:

### 1. LOVE BOMBING:

Intense attention, gifts, 'soulmate' talk, moving fast

### 2. DEVALUATION:

Criticism, gaslighting, withdrawal, triangulation

### 3. DISCARD:

Silent treatment, replacement, cruel exit

### 4. HOOVERING:

Comes back with apologies, promises, 'I've changed'

### 5. REPEAT:

The cycle starts again, each time more intense

Where I was in the cycle: \_\_\_\_\_

How many times the cycle repeated: \_\_\_\_\_

## AM I BEING GASLIT? CHECKLIST

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Gaslighting makes you doubt YOUR reality. Check what applies:

- ☐ They deny things you KNOW happened
- ☐ They say 'You're too sensitive' or 'You're crazy'
- ☐ You constantly second-guess yourself
- ☐ You feel confused about what's real
- ☐ You apologize for everything (even their behavior)
- ☐ They rewrite history and you start to believe them
- ☐ You feel like you're walking on eggshells
- ☐ You've stopped trusting your own memory
- ☐ You make excuses for their behavior to others
- ☐ You feel like you've lost yourself
- ☐ Other people say you've changed
- ☐ You're afraid to bring up concerns

**If you checked 3+: Trust yourself. Your experience is REAL.**

# THE FOG: Fear, Obligation, Guilt

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Narcissists keep you trapped using FOG:

**FEAR** - What am I afraid will happen if I leave/set boundaries?

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**OBLIGATION** - What do I feel I 'owe' them?

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**GUILT** - What do I feel guilty about?

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**TRUTH:** You don't owe your abuser anything. Fear and guilt are tools THEY installed in you. You can uninstall them.

# UNDERSTANDING TRAUMA BONDING

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Trauma bonds form through intermittent reinforcement:

Cruelty + occasional kindness = addiction to the relationship.

## **Signs of trauma bonding:**

- You miss them even though they hurt you
- You justify their abuse
- You believe you can 'fix' them
- Leaving feels physically painful
- You keep going back
- You defend them to others
- You feel addicted to the highs

**This is NOT love. This is a trauma response. And it CAN be broken.**

## NO-CONTACT / GRAY ROCK PLANNING

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### **NO CONTACT (if possible):**

Block on: ☐ Phone ☐ Text ☐ Email ☐ All social media

Flying monkeys to block/limit: \_\_\_\_\_

My plan if they show up: \_\_\_\_\_

### **GRAY ROCK (when no-contact isn't possible - coparenting, work):**

Be boring. Be brief. Be uninteresting. Give them NOTHING.

- Only discuss necessary topics (kids, work logistics)
- Don't share emotions, opinions, or personal info
- Use short answers: 'okay' 'noted' 'I'll think about it'
- Don't defend yourself (they'll use it against you)
- Communicate in writing when possible (evidence)

My gray rock phrases: \_\_\_\_\_

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## CHALLENGING INTERNALIZED BELIEFS

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**The belief: 'I am not enough'**

Where this came from:

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Evidence this is THEIR voice, not truth:

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**Rewritten belief (in MY voice):**

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## CHALLENGING INTERNALIZED BELIEFS

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**The belief: 'No one will believe me'**

Where this came from:

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People who DO believe me:

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**Rewritten belief (in MY voice):**

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## CHALLENGING INTERNALIZED BELIEFS

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**The belief: 'I provoked the abuse'**

Where this came from:

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Truth: Abuse is ALWAYS the abuser's choice:

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**Rewritten belief (in MY voice):**

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## CHALLENGING INTERNALIZED BELIEFS

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**The belief: 'I'll never be normal'**

Where this came from:

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Evidence of my healing/strength:

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**Rewritten belief (in MY voice):**

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## CHALLENGING INTERNALIZED BELIEFS

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**The belief: 'I deserved it'**

Where this came from:

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NO ONE deserves abuse. What I actually deserve:

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**Rewritten belief (in MY voice):**

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# RE-ESTABLISHING BOUNDARIES

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Narcissists taught you that your boundaries don't matter.

**They DO. Let's rebuild them:**

**Physical boundaries:**

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**Emotional boundaries:**

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**Time/energy boundaries:**

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**Digital/communication:**

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**What I will no longer tolerate from ANYONE:**

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## RED FLAGS FOR FUTURE RELATIONSHIPS

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**Now that you know the pattern, you can spot it early:**

- Love bombing (too much too fast)
- Isolating you from friends/family
- Needing to know where you are always
- Criticizing then saying 'just joking'
- Making everything about them
- Never apologizing sincerely
- Your gut says something is off
- You start to feel 'crazy' again
- They have zero accountability
- They triangulate (comparing you to exes)
- Excessive jealousy framed as 'love'
- You feel smaller around them

**Green flags I want instead:**

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## HEALING PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 1

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Week of: \_\_\_\_\_

Times I thought about them: \_\_\_\_ (no judgment - just tracking)

Times I almost broke no-contact: \_\_\_\_

Did I break it? [ ] No (proud!) [ ] Yes (no shame, try again)

**A boundary I held:**

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**A moment I trusted myself:**

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**Self-care I did:**

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**Something that triggered me & how I coped:**

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**Evidence I'm healing (even small):**

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## HEALING PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 2

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Week of: \_\_\_\_\_

Times I thought about them: \_\_\_\_ (no judgment - just tracking)

Times I almost broke no-contact: \_\_\_\_

Did I break it? [ ] No (proud!) [ ] Yes (no shame, try again)

**A boundary I held:**

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**A moment I trusted myself:**

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**Self-care I did:**

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**Something that triggered me & how I coped:**

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**Evidence I'm healing (even small):**

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## HEALING PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 3

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Week of: \_\_\_\_\_

Times I thought about them: \_\_\_\_ (no judgment - just tracking)

Times I almost broke no-contact: \_\_\_\_

Did I break it? [ ] No (proud!) [ ] Yes (no shame, try again)

**A boundary I held:**

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**A moment I trusted myself:**

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**Self-care I did:**

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**Something that triggered me & how I coped:**

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**Evidence I'm healing (even small):**

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## HEALING PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 4

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Week of: \_\_\_\_\_

Times I thought about them: \_\_\_\_ (no judgment - just tracking)

Times I almost broke no-contact: \_\_\_\_

Did I break it? [ ] No (proud!) [ ] Yes (no shame, try again)

**A boundary I held:**

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**A moment I trusted myself:**

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**Self-care I did:**

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**Something that triggered me & how I coped:**

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**Evidence I'm healing (even small):**

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## HEALING PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 5

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Week of: \_\_\_\_\_

Times I thought about them: \_\_\_\_ (no judgment - just tracking)

Times I almost broke no-contact: \_\_\_\_

Did I break it? [ ] No (proud!) [ ] Yes (no shame, try again)

**A boundary I held:**

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**A moment I trusted myself:**

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**Self-care I did:**

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**Something that triggered me & how I coped:**

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**Evidence I'm healing (even small):**

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## HEALING PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 6

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Week of: \_\_\_\_\_

Times I thought about them: \_\_\_\_ (no judgment - just tracking)

Times I almost broke no-contact: \_\_\_\_

Did I break it? [ ] No (proud!) [ ] Yes (no shame, try again)

**A boundary I held:**

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**A moment I trusted myself:**

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**Self-care I did:**

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**Something that triggered me & how I coped:**

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**Evidence I'm healing (even small):**

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## HEALING PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 7

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Week of: \_\_\_\_\_

Times I thought about them: \_\_\_\_ (no judgment - just tracking)

Times I almost broke no-contact: \_\_\_\_

Did I break it? [ ] No (proud!) [ ] Yes (no shame, try again)

**A boundary I held:**

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**A moment I trusted myself:**

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**Self-care I did:**

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**Something that triggered me & how I coped:**

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**Evidence I'm healing (even small):**

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## HEALING PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 8

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Week of: \_\_\_\_\_

Times I thought about them: \_\_\_\_ (no judgment - just tracking)

Times I almost broke no-contact: \_\_\_\_

Did I break it? [ ] No (proud!) [ ] Yes (no shame, try again)

**A boundary I held:**

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**A moment I trusted myself:**

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**Self-care I did:**

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**Something that triggered me & how I coped:**

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**Evidence I'm healing (even small):**

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# I AM NOT CRAZY

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**What happened to me was real.**

**My feelings are valid.**

**I am not 'too sensitive.'**

**I did not cause the abuse.**

**I did not deserve the abuse.**

**My memory is trustworthy.**

**I am not crazy for being affected.**

**The confusion I feel was CREATED by them.**

**I am stronger than I know.**

**I am allowed to be angry.**

**I am allowed to grieve.**

**I am allowed to heal at my own pace.**

**I am allowed to never forgive them.**

**I am worthy of healthy love.**

**I am reclaiming my life.**

Read this page whenever the self-doubt creeps back in.